



BOLLYWOOD DANCERS

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Twirl, twist, bend and lift

No longer dance extras or junior artistes, professional dancers have changed the way the Bollywood song-and-dance set piece looks

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

We counted. In about 18 minutes, Malti S. Dotiyal and Rakesh 'Raka' Sharma did the 5-6-7-8 11 times. The two are what everybody calls back-up dancers, who used to be called extras. But to the film industry, they are performers. A choreographer may visualise the moves, but it's the troupe and the assistants who take the stars through the twists, twirls, bends and lifts. "If an actor forgets a step, he turns around and asks us," says 23-year-old Dotiyal, who became a dancer after second-year junior college. Dancers today are not on stage for the money alone but because of the spotlight. Bosco, of the choreographer duo Bosco Caesar, says, "A lot of my dancers are educated people from secure families." Like Alfa Solanki, who steps into the green room dressed in a pair of tracks and steps out in a bronze-coloured outfit. She confidently climbs on to the stage, and does her 1-2-3. Solanki is into the dancing business just for the love of it. She graduated with a degree in

interior design from the L.S. Raheja School of Architecture, but found her calling in making the right moves. "I have always loved dancing. After college, I joined choreographer Ganesh Acharya," says Solanki, who has worked with big names in the industry. She knows that the career comes with a short shelf life. She says, "After I get married, dancing for a living won't be acceptable. Also, I can only dance till a certain age."

She's one of the lucky few. Most parents from the proverbial good families are still apprehensive about letting their children take up dancing as a profession. Take Dotiyal, for instance. She had to learn classical dancing for the sake of her family before she could start working with a choreographer. No wonder then that there are not enough buffed and burnished back-up artistes to feed Bollywood's dance craze, says Bosco, "There are only 25 boys and 25 girls in the industry who are good. We need about 100 each." Till then the same people will have to hang loose with Hrithik Roshan and undulate behind Abhishek Bachchan.